

others at the FTCP. This time he was arrested, zip-stripped, and taken to jail. He will probably be court-martialed.

These are wild days. It seems everyday now, some little terrorist stumbles up to one of our checkpoints with some vague information about an imminent attack on one of our locations. We check out their little terrorist stories and usually take some action to try to capture the would-be attackers, who never seem to turn up. I hate Iraq and all of the little jackasses in this country. As far as I am concerned they can have this hot, dusty, wasteland of a country.

Last night, some terrorist was firing flares near our TOC. Several of the flares landed inside our TOC area creating some unrest. The front gate guards then reported seeing tracer fire but could not determine whether or not they were being shot at. Chances are that if they couldn't tell, they were not being fired at. Either way, we sent two tanks to go check out the fields around our compound hoping to find the little Bin-Ladens. Of course we didn't find anything. Go figure.

Well, Colonel Ingram is going to try and let us wear our combat patches now—he hopes that this will alleviate some of the frustration in the unit. He hopes that this will serve as a token of appreciation and stop the spreading emotional distress. I think that it may help for a short time, but what people really need is a break or a date when we will go home. What we really need is contact with home, some hope. We need an Internet connection or telephones. We need to know how much longer we will be here, and we need a few days of rest. I don't think that getting combat patches is the right cure for the ailment, but it should lift the spirits of some of the younger guys—for a little while.

I miss you and Mason and I can't wait to come home.

Love,

A handwritten signature in cursive script, appearing to read "Christian".

Christian